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Daniel

The young exile who stayed faithful in Babylon for nearly seventy years, through kings, lions and visions of God's kingdom.

Daniel was taken from Jerusalem to Babylon as a youth and never came home. Trained to serve a pagan king and given a Babylonian name, he held on to the God of Israel from his first meal to his last vision. He explained kings' dreams, read the writing on the wall, prayed when prayer was against the law, and was kept safe among lions. He served Babylonian and Persian rulers for about seventy years without fault. His visions look past the empires of his day to a kingdom that "shall never be destroyed."

At a glance

Name	"God is my judge"; renamed Belteshazzar (Daniel 1:7)
Family	Of Judah's royal or noble youth; parents not named (Daniel 1:3–6)
Taken to Babylon	As a youth, c. 605 BC
Served	Nebuchadnezzar, Belshazzar, Darius the Mede and Cyrus
Friends	Hananiah, Mishael and Azariah (Shadrach, Meshach and Abednego)
Last dated vision	The third year of Cyrus, c. 536 BC (Daniel 10:1)
Main passages	Daniel 1–12; Ezekiel 14:14, 20; 28:3
New Testament	"Daniel the prophet" (Matthew 24:15; Mark 13:14)

"But Daniel purposed in his heart that he would not defile himself with the portion of the king's meat, nor with the wine which he drank."

Daniel 1:8, KJV

The life of Daniel

Dates are approximate (BC). The book is partly arranged by theme; Belshazzar's first year (c. 553 BC) is uncertain.

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| c. 605–602 BC
<i>As a youth</i> | ● Taken to Babylon and tested
Chosen to train for the king's court and renamed Belteshazzar, Daniel refuses the king's food. After ten days he and his friends look healthier than the rest.
<i>Daniel 1:1–20</i> |
| c. 603 BC
<i>Nebuchadnezzar's 2nd year</i> | ● The king's dream revealed
Facing death with the wise men, Daniel prays. God shows him the dream, and the king makes him ruler over Babylon's province. <i>Daniel 2:1–49</i> |
| c. 553 BC
<i>Belshazzar's 1st year</i> | ● Four beasts and the Son of man
He sees four beasts, then "one like the Son of man" receive an everlasting kingdom. <i>Daniel 7:1–14</i> |
| c. 539 BC
<i>The night Babylon falls</i> | ● The writing on the wall
Daniel, now old, reads God's verdict at Belshazzar's feast. That night Belshazzar is killed. <i>Daniel 5:1–31</i> |
| c. 539 BC
<i>Darius's 1st year</i> | ● Praying over the seventy years
Reading Jeremiah, he confesses his people's sins, and Gabriel brings the vision of the seventy weeks. <i>Daniel 9:1–27</i> |
| Under Darius, date not given | ● The lions' den
Trapped by a law against prayer, he prays anyway and is thrown to the lions. God shuts their mouths. <i>Daniel 6:1–28</i> |
| c. 536 BC
<i>Cyrus's 3rd year</i> | ● The last vision
By the Tigris he receives his final vision and is told to "go thou thy way till the end be." <i>Daniel 10:1–4; 12:13</i> |

Key activities

Christians differ over when Daniel was written: traditionally by Daniel in the 500s BC; many modern scholars say its final form dates to about 165 BC, under Antiochus IV.

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- I Resolved not to defile himself.** He asked for vegetables and water instead of the king's food. *Daniel 1:8-16*

 - 2 Excelled in learning.** God gave him "understanding in all visions and dreams." *Daniel 1:17-20*

 - 3 Prayed with his friends.** Facing death, they sought mercy from "the God of heaven." *Daniel 2:17-23*

 - 4 Gave God the credit.** "There is a God in heaven that revealeth secrets." *Daniel 2:27-45*

 - 5 Spoke hard truth kindly.** He urged Nebuchadnezzar to turn from his sins and show mercy to the poor. *Daniel 4:19-27*

 - 6 Turned down rewards.** He told Belshazzar to keep his gifts, then read the writing and its judgment plainly. *Daniel 5:17-28*

 - 7 Served without fault.** His rivals could find no corruption in his work, only his faithfulness to his God. *Daniel 6:3-5*

 - 8 Kept praying.** When the law forbade it, he knelt at his open window toward Jerusalem three times a day, "as he did aforetime." *Daniel 6:10*

 - 9 Survived the lions.** God sent his angel and shut the lions' mouths, and King Darius praised "the living God." *Daniel 6:16-27*

 - 10 Confessed his people's sin.** He prayed, "we do not present our supplications before thee for our righteousnesses, but for thy great mercies." *Daniel 9:3-19*

 - II Received visions of the end.** He saw empires rise and fall, and he was promised that many who sleep in the dust will awake. *Daniel 7-8; 10-12*

Across Scripture

Direct references first. Echoes are study links, not places that name Daniel.

Old Testament

Daniel 1–12	The main account of his life and visions
Ezekiel 14:14, 20; 28:3	With Noah and Job; some think an older hero Danel
Jeremiah 25:11–12; 29:10	The seventy years Daniel studied (Daniel 9:2)

New Testament

Matthew 24:15; Mark 13:14	Jesus cites "Daniel the prophet"
Matthew 26:64	"Coming in the clouds of heaven," from Daniel 7:13
Hebrews 11:33	Heroes of faith who "stopped the mouths of lions"
Echo: Revelation 13; John 5:28–29	Daniel's beasts; the dead rising
Tradition	Susanna and Bel and the Dragon are Greek additions (Apocrypha)

For discussion

1. *Observe:* What did Daniel do once the law against prayer was signed (Daniel 6:10)?
2. *Understand:* Daniel served pagan kings well but would not break God's law. How did he draw the line?
3. *Apply:* Daniel "purposed in his heart" before the test. What decision could you settle now?
4. *Apply:* His prayer habit was in place long before the lions. What daily habit could you start or protect?